ANOMIE (EMILE DURKHEIM)

Emile Durkheim (1858-1917)

- One of the most important figures in sociology.
- His work has important insights about the sociological method (Rules of Sociological Method, 1894) as also various other social phenomena like suicide, division of labour, religion and the like.
- Let us watch a short video-
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=z9W0GQvONKc&t=19s&authuser=1

What is common in them?

Source: John Macionis (2017). P. 131

- People with “weak social bonds”; sometimes engaging in “self destructive behaviour”
- Sudden fame- loss of familiar life patterns and existing relationships.
- Why the celebrities from the world of Rock and Roll seem so prone to self destructive behaviour?
- Durkheim attempted to answer this-
- Highest suicide rates are found amongst people with lowest level of social integration.
- Society provides the moral discipline that guides our behaviour and controls our desires.
- *Anomie:* a condition in which society provides little moral guidance to individuals.
- Rapid social change and anomie.

A more recent example

Jewar airport: When farmers became crorepatis overnight, then lost it all on luxuries

For generations, land was the farmers' only steady asset, producing food, income and security. Compensation replaced that asset with a lump sum, but this money came without financial planning support, guidance or long-term safeguards.

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Durkheim: Key Ideas

- Two major themes exist in all of Durkheim's works:
- 1. On making sociology as a viable academic discipline. Sociology as a study of **'social facts'.**
- 2. He sought to explore the nature of bonds that hold the individuals and social groups together- the idea of **social solidarity,** (what are the two kinds?), **collective conscience**.
- What happens when these bonds weaken?
- The extent to which individuals are bound together in an increasingly individualistic world.

- *“There can be no society which does not feel the need of upholding and reaffirming at regular intervals the collective sentiments and the collective ideas which makes its unity and its personality. Now this moral remaking cannot be achieved except by the means of reunions, assemblies and meetings where the individuals, being closely united to one another, reaffirm in common their common sentiments.”*
- -Emile Durkheim

- Thus, shared and collective moral sentiments are integral in Durkheim’s work.

- In his first major work, *The Division of Labour in Society,* he talks about the two kinds of solidarities that exist in simple, traditional societies and industrialised modern societies.
- **Mechanical solidarity** and **Organic solidarity.**
- Durkheim maintained that organic solidarity does not always automatically emerge in a society, the DoL has to be spontaneous or voluntary. If it is stretched too far, there is a danger for the individual to become "isolated in his special activity".
- The individual "no longer feels the idea of common work being done by those who work side by side with him". Also a rigid division of labour can lead to "the institution of classes and castes…[which] is often a source of dissension".
- He emphasised that over specialisation thwarts organic solidarity (the feeling of oneness based on interdependence) because of instigating interdependence it instigates isolation.
- He used the term **anomie** to refer to the pathological lack of moral regulation in modern societies.

Suicide: A study in Sociology (1897)

- He further deals with the idea of **anomie** in his work on suicide where he argued that an act, seemingly individual and thought to be driven entirely by psychological factors, is in fact social in nature. (Individual 'pathologies' as rooted in social conditions).
- He analysed data to show the social factors and their relationship with the rates of suicide.
- He sought to explain why occurrence of suicide is rare in *small and simple* societies but more frequent in modern industrial ones.

- Specifically, Durkheim saw two main characteristics of the modern, industrial society:
- 1. A lack of integration of the individual in the social group. (social integration)
- 2. A lack of moral regulation. (moral regulation)

- Based on these characteristics, he proposes different kinds of suicides
- Egoistic suicide
- Anomic suicide
- Altruistic suicide
- Fatalistic suicide